

Lecture – 02

Faith & Beliefs

A person asked Allah's Messenger (peace be upon him): *“what is faith?”* He said: *“when a good deed becomes a source of pleasure for you and an evil deed becomes a source of disgust for you, then you are a believer.”* He again said Allah's Messenger: *“what is a sin?”* Whereupon he said: *“when something pricks your conscience, give it up.”* (Tirmidhi)

Belief in God (*Iman Billah*)

- ▶ Are we Muslims allowed to raise questions on religious matters?
 - ▶ The Quran mentions in the very beginning that true believers are those who believe ‘*bi’l-ghayb*’ (2:3); the expression ‘*bi’l-ghayb*’ is translated by some to mean ‘*blind faith*’.
- ▶ The other reason mentioned from the Quran is that the book of Allah, it is claimed, discourages believers from asking questions. It is mentioned in the Quran, for instance, thus:

▶ الَّذِينَ يُؤْمِنُونَ بِالْغَيْبِ

أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا لَا تَسْأَلُوا عَنْ أَشْيَاءٍ إِنْ تُبَدَّ لَكُمْ تَسْأَلُكُمْ وَإِنْ تَسْأَلُوا عَنْهَا حِينَ يُنَزَّلُ الْقُرْآنُ تُبَدَّ لَكُمْ عَفَا اللَّهُ عَنْهَا وَاللَّهُ غَفُورٌ حَلِيمٌ

O believers! ask not questions about things which if made plain to you may cause you trouble. But if you ask about things when the Qur'an is being revealed they will be made plain to you: God will forgive those: for God is Oft-Forgiving Most Forbearing. (5:101)

- We shall see from the correct understanding of the two passages that the book of Allah is not discouraging Muslims in either of these verses from asking genuine questions. However, quite apart from that, it is worth considering that we are told in the Quran that when Allah Almighty announced His decision to create man, an independent creation, Khalifah (commonly translated as vicegerent), the angels, who are normally considered as a creation that would most obediently comply to all commands of Allah, raised a few questions. The tone of those questions suggests that initially they were not quite appreciating fully the divine scheme. Allah Almighty, it seems from the Quranic description of the occasion, instead of admonishing them for having dared to raise those questions, went ahead with the task of providing them with satisfactory answers. (See Quran 2:30-33).

- وَإِذْ قَالَ رَبُّكَ لِلْمَلَائِكَةِ إِنِّي جَاعِلٌ فِي الْأَرْضِ خَلِيفَةً ۖ قَالُوا أَتَجْعَلُ فِيهَا مَن يُفْسِدُ فِيهَا وَيَسْفِكُ الدِّمَاءَ وَنَحْنُ نُسَبِّحُ بِحَمْدِكَ وَنُقَدِّسُ لَكَ ۖ قَالَ إِنِّي أَعْلَمُ مَا لَا تَعْلَمُونَ ۖ وَعَلَّمَ آدَمَ الْأَسْمَاءَ كُلَّهَا ثُمَّ عَرَضَهُمْ عَلَى الْمَلَائِكَةِ فَقَالَ أَنْبِئُونِي بِأَسْمَاءِ هَؤُلَاءِ إِنْ كُنْتُمْ صَادِقِينَ ۖ قَالُوا سُبْحَانَكَ لَا عِلْمَ لَنَا إِلَّا مَا عَلَّمْتَنَا إِنَّكَ أَنْتَ الْعَلِيمُ الْحَكِيمُ ۖ قَالَ يَا آدَمُ أَنْبِئْهُمْ بِأَسْمَائِهِمْ ۖ فَلَمَّا أَنْبَأَهُمْ بِأَسْمَائِهِمْ قَالَ أَلَمْ أَقُلْ لَكُمْ إِنِّي أَعْلَمُ غَيْبَ السَّمَاوَاتِ وَالْأَرْضِ وَأَعْلَمُ مَا تُبْدُونَ وَمَا كُنْتُمْ تَكْتُمُونَ

Behold your Lord said to the angels: "I will create a vicegerent on earth." They said "Wilt thou place therein one who will make mischief therein and shed blood? Whilst we do celebrate Thy praises and glorify Thy holy (name)?" He said: "I know what ye know not." And He taught Adam the nature of all things; then He placed them before the angels and said: "Tell Me the nature of these if ye are right." They said: "Glory to Thee of knowledge we have none save that Thou hast taught us: in truth it is Thou who art perfect in knowledge and wisdom." He said: "O Adam! tell them their natures." When he had told them God said: "Did I not tell you that I know the secrets of heaven and earth and I know what ye reveal and what ye conceal?" (2:30-33)

وَاِذْ قَالَ مُوسٰى لِقَوْمِهٖ اِنَّ اللّٰهَ يَامُرُكُمْ اَنْ تَذْبَحُوْا بَقْرَةًۭ ۖ قَالُوْٓا اَتَتَّخِذُنَا هُزُوًاۙ قَالَ اَعُوْذُ بِاللّٰهِ اَنْ اَكُوْنَ مِنَ الْجَاهِلِيْنَ ۖۙ اَلَاۤءِىْ هٰذَا رَبِّكَ يُبَيِّنْ لَّنَا مَا هِيَۚ قَالَ اِنَّهٗ يَقُوْلُ اِنَّهَا۟ بَقْرَةٌۭ لَاۤ اَرِضٌ وَلَاۤ بَكْرٌۭ عَوَٰنٌۢ بَيْنَۤ ذٰلِكَۙ صَافًۭىۚ فَعَلُوْٓا مَا تُؤْمَرُوْنَ ۖۙ اَلَاۤءِىْ هٰذَا رَبِّكَ يُبَيِّنْ لَّنَا مَا هِيَۚ قَالَ اِنَّهٗ يَقُوْلُ اِنَّهَا۟ بَقْرَةٌۭ صَفْرًاۙ فَاقْعَ لَوْثُهَاۙ تَسْرُ النَّاْظِرِيْنَ ۖۙ اَلَاۤءِىْ هٰذَا رَبِّكَ يُبَيِّنْ لَّنَا مَا هِيَۚ اِنَّ الْبَقْرَ تَشَابَهَ عَلَيْنَا وَاِنَّا اِنْ شَاءَ اللّٰهُ لَمُهْتَدُوْنَ ۖۙ اَلَاۤءِىْ هٰذَا رَبِّكَ يُبَيِّنْ لَّنَا مَا هِيَۚ قَالَ اِنَّهٗ يَقُوْلُ اِنَّهَا۟ بَقْرَةٌۭ لَاۤ ذَلُوْلٌۢ تُثِيْرُ الْاَرْضَ وَلَا تَسْقِي الْحَرْثَ مُسَلَّمَةٌۭ لَاۤ شِيْءَ فِيْهَاۙ قَالُوْٓا اَلَاۤ اِنَّ جِئْتَ بِالْحَقِّۚۙ فَذَبَحُوهَا وَمَا كَادُوْٓا يَفْعَلُوْنَ

And remember Moses said to his people: "God commands that ye sacrifice a heifer." They said: "Makest thou a laughing-stock of us?" He said: "God save me from being an ignorant (fool)!" They said: "Beseech on our behalf thy Lord to make plain to us what (heifer) it is! He said: "He says: The heifer should be neither too old nor too young but of middling age; now do what ye are commanded!. They said: "Beseech on our behalf thy Lord to make plain to us her color." He said: " He says a fawn-colored heifer pure and rich in tone the admiration of beholders!" They said "Beseech on our behalf thy Lord to make plain to us what she is to us are all heifers alike; we wish indeed for guidance if God wills." He said: "He says a heifer not trained to till the soil or water the fields; sound and without blemish." They said: "Now hast thou brought the truth." Then they offered her in sacrifice but not with good- will. (2:67-71)

Is it unscientific to believe in the unseen?

The only correct answer to this is that it most certainly is not. There are realities which are acknowledged by the present-day scientists without even asking for their arguments, even though they are beyond the reach of the five senses. The phenomenon of gravity is a case in point. Nobody has ever seen or touched it, and yet it still remains an indisputable scientific reality, simply because it makes logical sense that there has to be an ability in the earth which always makes objects fall on the ground instead of allowing them to move towards the sky. In other words, the data available through sense perception (all objects having a tendency of falling on the ground) was analysed to bring forth a conclusion (the presence of gravity) that was considered acceptable because of the strength of the intellectual argument (recurrence of the same phenomenon with uninterrupted regularity). Thus if there are other unseen realities the existence of which is attempted to be presented in much the same manner as that of gravity, their arguments too should be considered equally objectively, and the claims should not be rejected merely on the plea that the claim is requiring us to believe in something that cannot be seen.

Source of Knowledge

- ▶ **Intuition** is one of those sources. We are born with the knowledge of a few things. They are with us a priori (in born). For instance, we already know the understanding of a whole from a part, right from wrong, and certain things aesthetically pleasant while others unpleasant etc. It is claimed, likewise, that God is part of our intuitional knowledge. People of all ages have believed in God. Their description of God may be different, but in all nations there has been a clear understanding of an ultimate Creator. It is an almost unanimously accepted reality about which there are only a few people who dispute. Those who do not believe in God at all have always been a very small minority.
- ▶ **Sense perception** – the ability of the five senses through which we perceive information – is another source of knowledge. Anything perceived through the five senses is normally considered to be authentic information and is considered an undeniable part of our knowledge. For instance, we see the sun, we touch the smooth surface of a table, we taste a sweet mango etc. and we get information about these objects which is not doubted. Another way we learn about realities is through the experiences of others who either live in other parts of the world or else who lived in this world before us. Their experiences are recorded and passed on to others to form a part of the commonly shared knowledge of all human beings.
- ▶ **Intellect** is the third source of our understanding. It analyses the data already available to us through our intuition, sense perception, and historical records and draws conclusions. The process involves application of what is called common sense as well as logic. If the arguments in the presentation are strong, the idea is accepted as a convincing piece of information like any other source.

Divine Attributes:

When one looks around the physical world one is struck by the fact that there is amazing harmony and order in the creation. Whether it is the alternating appearances of days and nights, monthly appearances of the moon, growing of crops, or the functioning of human body, everything seems to be following a strict 'code of conduct'. There isn't a danger in this world – or at least it hasn't been experienced in the recorded history – that heavenly bodies, for instance, would bang against each other and thereby cause the whole existence to collapse. – Qudrat

Another aspect of our worldly experience towards which the Quran draws our attention is the reality that it is not just a display of raw power that we observe in our surroundings; what is more directly significant for our appreciation is the fact that a good part of the immediately observable natural phenomena is serving us. The mountains and rivers, the sun and the moon, the alternating days and nights, the rainfall, the air we breathe, the plants, the crops and vegetation we get – all happening within a controlled system – are all, as if, performing in unison to ensure our survival. It is amazing, for instance, that the rainfall that we need for our crops and to get water for the purpose of our own survival is caused by a harmonious interaction of different elements of nature. It is puzzling to learn that the sun is distanced from our earth by exactly the margin that is good enough for our survival to be possible. – Rububbiyat

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- ▶ A third aspect of our present worldly life pointed out by the Quran is that while on the one hand we deeply love our worldly life, on the other we know that we were not entitled to get it i.e. we didn't do anything to get this life. In other words, we also experience in this world, according to the Quranic jargon, the display of mercy – **Rahmat**.
 - ▶ Another aspect pointed at by the Quran is the fact that it is not mere manifestation of order in the universe, nor existence of simple arrangements meant to ensure our survival that one experiences, what is also observable to a keen viewer is the fact that the system is functioning extremely intelligently. It seems that there are objectives set forth on the one hand and there are measures adopted to achieve them in extremely subtle, complex, and 'miraculous' ways on the other.
– Hikmat

- ▶ In other words, it is only belief in God that takes you out of the pitch darkness of the anxiety of unbelief. You acknowledge the existence of the Almighty God and everything would seem meaningful; all scattered pieces of the puzzle would fall into their respective, proper places. All immediately relevant, intriguing questions would get answered. In the words of a scholar: 'The mystery of this world to me was like a lock that wouldn't open. I applied various keys, but they didn't work. Then I applied the key of faith in Allah, and it spontaneously opened. That to me is the most convincing reason for my belief in the existence of God.' Another way of looking at the question of the possibility of existence of God is to look at relative strengths of the suggestions that are offered as alternatives to belief in God. It is considered, at least by some people, that the alternatives to the belief in one God Who is the Creator of the heavens and the earth are found in the concepts of polytheism, atheism, the theory of evolution, and the big bang theory.

We have been informed by our modern scientific enlightenment about the entire process of rainfall, right from the evaporation of water in the oceans and cloud formation till the flowing back of the same water back to the seas where it originated from. Learning the working of this process leads some people to the erroneous, superficial conclusion that all relevant learning about rainfall has been done. However, going by the same logic, let us examine the description of a person who informs us about his experience of a particularly sultry day when his throat and tongue were parched and he was desperately looking for water. What impression would the description create on us if the individual narrates his story thus: I at last found the entrance door of a house and knocked at it. Someone opened the door. I requested for water. In response, a hand reached a fridge door and opened it, bringing out a bottle of cold water. The hand then poured water from it into a glass and offered the glass to me. Obviously, the entire description would be painfully absurd, because it isn't the unnecessary details of the process of getting water which we would be interested in learning. On the contrary, we would have liked to know the person who was kind enough to come to the aid of our story teller. Likewise, is the case of the scientific descriptions explaining the phenomena of nature. They are a bland description of the process, without even a mention of the one behind it.

The immediate question that one is confronted with on acknowledging one's belief in Allah is this: How can I know Him more? How can I appreciate and come closer to Him? It has been clarified in the Quran that we can neither see God's physical existence nor can we know anything about it. All efforts in that direction would prove to be not only futile but even misleading as well. The Quran says:

وَلَمَّا جَاءَ مُوسَىٰ لِمِيقَاتِنَا وَكَلَّمَهُ رَبُّهُ قَالَ رَبِّ أَرِنِي أَنظُرْ إِلَيْكَ ۖ قَالَ لَن تَرَانِي وَلَكِنِ انْظُرْ إِلَى الْجَبَلِ فَإِنِ اسْتَقَرَّ مَكَانَهُ فَسَوْفَ تَرَانِي ۖ فَلَمَّا تَجَلَّىٰ رَبُّهُ لِلْجَبَلِ جَعَلَهُ دَكًّا وَخَرَّ مُوسَىٰ صَعِقًا ۖ فَلَمَّا أَفَاقَ قَالَ سُبْحَانَكَ تُبْتُ إِلَيْكَ وَأَنَا أَوَّلُ الْمُؤْمِنِينَ

And when Moses came to Our appointed time and his Lord spoke to him, he said: 'My Lord! Show Thyself to me that I may look at Thee'. Allah replied: You shall not see Me, but look at the mountain! If it remains in its place, then you can see Me. And when his Lord manifested Himself on the mountain, He sent it crashing down. And Moses fell down senseless. And when he woke he said: 'Glory unto You! I turn to You and I am the first to believe'. (7:143)

In another verse the Quran says:

لَّا تُدْرِكُهُ الْأَبْصَارُ وَهُوَ يُدْرِكُ الْأَبْصَارَ ۖ وَهُوَ اللَّطِيفُ الْخَبِيرُ

No vision can grasp Him, but His grasp is over all visions. (6:104)

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- ▶ How then can we appreciate God beyond the mere information of His presence? The answer that emerges from the Quran is that the only way to know Him more and more is through increasing our understanding of His attributes. The more we concentrate on appreciating His capabilities and potentialities, the more we'll be able to come close to Him. His attributes are the only way of knowing God.
 - ▶ All the names of Allah (with the probable exception of Allah) are indicators of His different attributes. Since all knowledge about Allah is based on the proper appreciation of His attributes, it is important that some important principles about His attributes be recognised. Those principles are: 1) All good attributes belong to Him. The above-mentioned verse clarifies this truth. In other words, all important virtues we can imagine of are present in Allah. 2) All His attributes are perfect: they are both qualitatively supreme and quantitatively infinite. For instance, while our knowledge is limited, His knowledge is limitless, ie, it encompasses all past, present, and future information. 3) All these attributes are simultaneously operative. It is not that on some occasions He is Powerful, for instance, while on others He is Knowledgeable, and on still others He is Merciful. Instead, he effectively possesses all these attributes all the time. If we ignore this understanding, we are very likely to adopt a one-sided, misleading view of God.

We learn from the Quran that this world of ours is a manifestation of God's attributes. Thus the more we reflect upon our surroundings in the light of the understanding of God's attributes, the more we are likely to develop His true Ma'rifat (cognisance). The process is in actual fact a potentially endless chain of observations and confirmations – observations of God's Ayat (signs) and spiritual confirmation of the truthfulness of the existence God's attributes. Thus, Dhikr (remembering Allah), which is mentioned as an important requirement in the Quran for the believers to undertake, involves both remembering Allah through the understanding of His attributes and observing those attributes manifesting themselves in His signs (Ayat) spread all across the surroundings. The Quran says:

إِنَّ فِي خَلْقِ السَّمَاوَاتِ وَالْأَرْضِ وَاخْتِلَافِ اللَّيْلِ وَالنَّهَارِ لَآيَاتٍ لِأُولِي الْأَلْبَابِ | الَّذِينَ يَذْكُرُونَ اللَّهَ قِيَامًا
وَقُعُودًا وَعَلَىٰ جُنُوبِهِمْ وَيَتَفَكَّرُونَ فِي خَلْقِ السَّمَاوَاتِ وَالْأَرْضِ رَبَّنَا مَا خَلَقْتَ هَذَا بَاطِلًا سُبْحَانَكَ فَقِنَا عَذَابَ
النَّارِ

In the creation of the heavens and the earth and in the alternation of the night and the day there are indeed signs for men of understanding – those who remember Allah standing, sitting, and lying on their sides, and ponder over the creation of the heavens and the earth (3:190-1).